MY WORDS: BLACK

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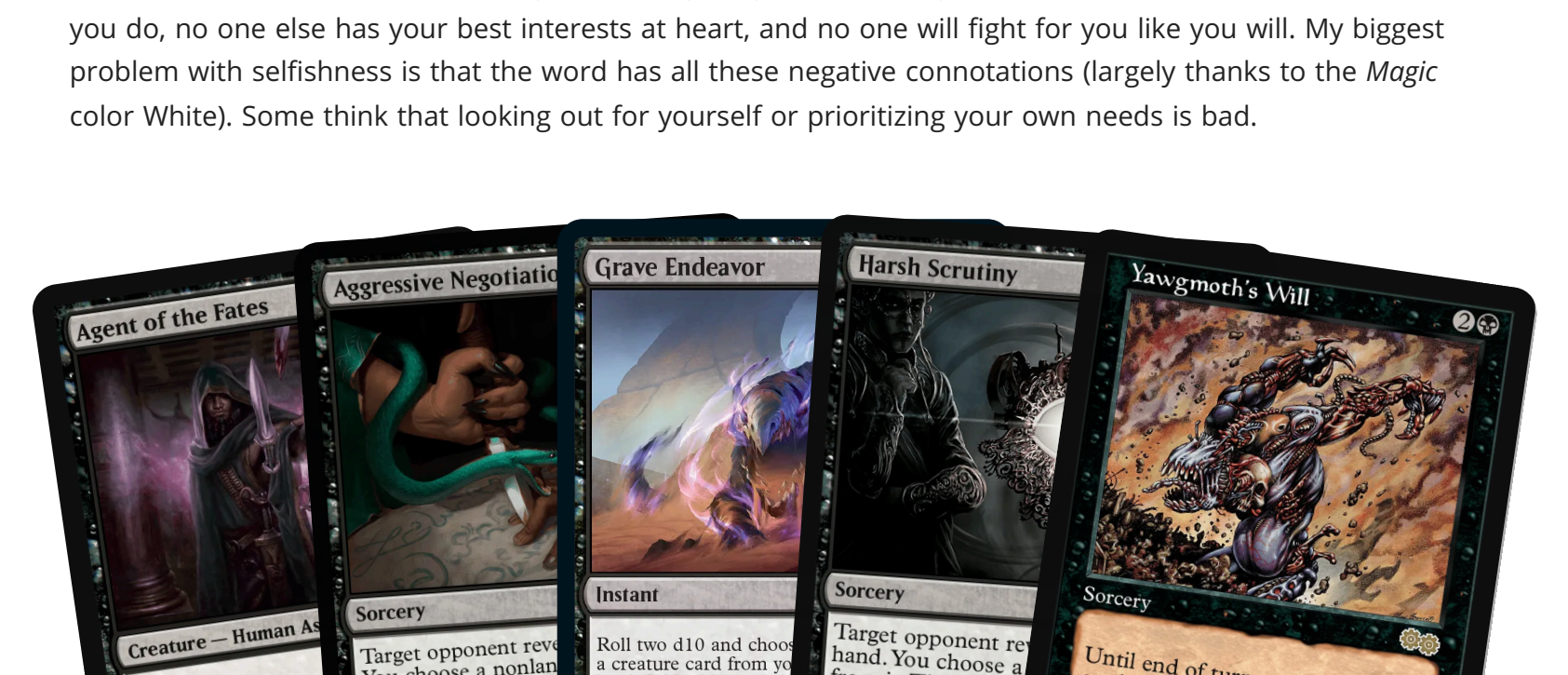
Hello, everyone. This is the *Magic* color Black. Mark, the author of this column, is doing a five-article series that he's calling "My Words," where he's giving each of the *Magic* colors an article to allow us to talk directly to all of you and give first-hand accounts of our philosophies. This is based on a series he did for his podcast *Drive to Work*. White and Blue have already gone, so today, it is my turn.

One of the reasons I want to write this article is that I believe, of the five colors of *Magic*, I'm the most misunderstood. People seem to want to ascribe nefarious motives to what I want, and that couldn't be further from the truth. So, what exactly do I want? Put simply, I want every person to have the opportunity to thrive. I have no expectation that every person will thrive. In fact, I know objectively that most won't. I just want those who work hard and dedicate themselves to a better life to have the chance to do so.

Of the five *Magic* colors, I'm the most pragmatic. I see the world as it is: a harsh place where many suffer. As a result, people are fundamentally selfish, but I don't see that as a bad thing. Everyone deserves someone to look out for them, and you can only truly look out for yourself. No one else sees the world as you do, no one else has your best interests at heart, and no one will fight for you like you will. My biggest problem with selfishness is that the word has all these negative connotations (largely thanks to the *Magic* color White). Some think that looking out for yourself or prioritizing your own needs is bad.



My worldview is that everyone deserves to be their own champion. If someone is willing to do what it takes to thrive, they should have the opportunity to do so. I believe in a merit-based system. People's fates rise and fall with their accomplishments.

I also believe that not everyone will succeed, and that's okay. It's not your job to worry about the suffering of others. You should focus on yourself. If they fall short, stumble, or need help, that's not your problem, it's theirs. Some hear this and ask about loved ones and friends. If you have the means to help those who are important to you, you can and should do that provided it doesn't conflict with your own needs. It's like being on a sinking ship: you're of no use to anyone if you don't put on your own life vest first.

You do what you need to do to survive and thrive. That means capitalizing on your advantages, using your resources, and prioritizing yourself. The biggest problem most people have is their unwillingness to capitalize on opportunity.

I think most people run their lives based on fear. Opportunities present themselves and people opt not to take them because they're worried about what might happen. They do this for many reasons, whether they're afraid of failure, worried that it would change the status quo, or are apprehensive at the prospect of doing something they're "not supposed to do." Humans come up with so many reasons not to do the things that fundamentally they know they want to do.

You should believe that you're worthy of being the best, of doing the best, and of having the best. And yes, taking risks comes with taking chances. But you know what comes with not taking chances? Failure. Look at every successful person, and you will see a trend: they are willing to do the things that others aren't. I'm not talking about being reckless. I'm talking about being careful and methodical in what choices you're making. I'm talking about being ruthless in your pursuit of excellence.

It's important to keep in mind that life is a zero-sum game. If you're gaining something, someone else is losing it. What I mean by that is gain inherently comes with loss. You should take no shame in acquiring things. Where there are winners, there are also losers. But that's okay. They earned it. They were able to do something better than someone else.

You can apply that same line of thinking to work. When you get a job, you earn it. Nobody else gets that job. When you acquire a resource—money, status, influence—someone else misses out because you earned it instead. Life is about taking those opportunities and doing so without remorse. Don't be sad for the players that didn't get the trophy, the people that didn't get the job, or the individuals that didn't get the resource. They didn't get them because they weren't as good as you.

I believe that the ultimate goal of any individual should be reaching the point where they can do whatever they want to do. A person should strive to be able to make anything happen if they want it to happen. You have the means to live your life on your own terms. You can call it whatever you like: success, achievement, personal growth. Personally, I like to call it power. Most people won't get the level of power that I strive for. Power is for a select few. Part of success involves dealing with the fact that you succeeded where others failed, but their failure is not your concern.

So how exactly is one supposed to get power? I'll be gracious and share some secrets with you. Just remember my role in helping you. First, you have to figure out what you want. A lot of people fail at this. They wander around aimlessly and are unsure of what their future entails. The key to success is focus. There's no way to accomplish anything if you don't know what you're trying to accomplish. I suggest choosing something that is valuable to you. It can be a thing, a person, a position, or an accolade. It should be something that improves your life.

Second, figure out what exactly you have to do to acquire that valuable thing. Make a list. Write down the steps you would need to take. Be exhaustive. And if you're not sure what exactly the steps are, write down every possible step you can think of. What is everything—and I truly mean everythin—that you could do to get what you desire? A big reason for failure is a lack of insight. Success comes from exploring all your options.

Third, figure out what obstacles come with each of these steps. What's in your way? Is it a person, a set of rules, your own internal reluctance? What would stop you from acquiring that step? This is another big hurdle to success: an unwillingness to properly gauge your obstacles.

Fourth, make a list of every resource you currently have access to. This is the area where most people fall short. Many people don't succeed because they're unwilling to do what it takes to achieve their goals. What tools are available to you? You need to be creative and ruthless.

There is one more step, and it is (in some ways) the simplest and the hardest step. Use all the resources available to you (step four) to overcome the obstacles (step three) to do the things you need to do (step two) to get the thing you want (step one). Lather, rinse, repeat. Each step will get you closer to your goal. Just keep focused, follow the plan, and do whatever it takes.

Will there be risks? Yes. Will there be sacrifices? Most likely. Will you have to do things that will make others think badly about you? Probably, but who cares? If you do what needs to be done and get the things that matter, you will acquire power. You will control your own destiny. You will be your own champion.

I'll now talk about your greatest challenges, which I will use as a means of discussing each of the other colors. I'll start with one of my enemy colors, White. White is a master of convincing people to act against their own interests. White is very good at selling people on the idea that what they want is not what they need. I'll admit, I don't understand why that rhetoric works, but I'm kind of jealous. This is a huge thorn in my side. Playing to people's self-interest is powerful and effective. When people stop prioritizing their own needs, it becomes a lot harder to sway them to my side.

White has this whole "good of the group" scam they run. It's based on the idea that if everyone gives up any hope of being happy, they can be less miserable. It is an admirable con. The dangerous part of selling everyone on this scam is a concept called morality, which is the idea that certain things are "good" and others "evil." Conveniently, whatever White does is good and whatever I do is evil. Again, morality is just a made-up story that White tells to get people to act against their own interests.

Through a combination of fear and guilt, White manipulates people into not just believing their phony ideas but also framing me as a villain. This makes it harder to accomplish my goals and creates endless headaches. The key to fighting this involves leaning into the knowledge that people are inherently selfish. White can fool them, but when you offer people things they secretly desire, you can overwrite a lot of programming.

I do respect White's ability to organize, and I have been able to co-opt many of White's creations, like law and religion, to bend them to my own needs. White is very effective at making tools. And again, it's hard not to admire the brainwashing that White is able to do.

Next up is my other enemy color, Green. Green has their own dangerous ideas, the most problematic being the concept of destiny. Destiny says you can't have the things you want because "they weren't meant for you." According to who? Green, apparently. Green, through the concept of destiny, is the arbiter of what is supposed to be and what isn't supposed to be. Much like White's morality, things that work to Green's benefit are what's "destined to be." Meanwhile, the things that I want are "an abomination of nature."

But it gets worse. A core part of Green's concept of nature is this idea of survival of the fittest. This idea says that the evolution of nature is about the strongest surviving. Okay, so if I get in a fight with someone and I kill them, aren't I the strongest? Didn't I survive instead of them? No, I'm "usurping the natural order." I'm disrupting the web of life. But if a bear kills a stag, that's just fine. That's nature being nature. You can see the bias.

Another challenge with Green is that most of their creatures act more on instinct than intellect. Sometimes you can scare them, but it's hard to appeal to their selfish nature, so they can be trickier to motivate than other colors.

I'm a big advocate of death, and Green is the only other color that truly appreciates death, although it seems scared to use it as a tool. Green has a level of ferocity that I admire and is more willing than most to do what it takes to get what it wants.

Next up are my ally colors. I'll start with Red. What I really enjoy about Redis that it is the color of action. If Red wants something, they will do something about it. Red doesn't sit and complain when life doesn't go their way; they figure out what needs to be done and they do that. One of my least favorite things is when people complain that their life isn't going the way they want it to and don't take steps to make it better. Red doesn't do that. Red has a drive and a passion unlike any other color.

Red is also not afraid to make use of the tools available to them. For example, Red is good at destroying things. Most other colors shy away from destruction, as if it's something to be ashamed of. Red recognizes their strengths and isn't afraid to use them. Red also understands that getting what you need sometimes comes at the expense of others standing in your way. If you become an obstacle for Red, Red will remove you.

Red also understands the importance of enjoying life, living it to its fullest, and taking the time to savor what you have. What's the point of getting what you want if you can't enjoy it?

My biggest problem with Red is that they're a bit reckless, even for my taste. I understand taking risks, but they need to be calculated risks. Red is often short-sighted in a way that's problematic in the long-term. I'm not against indulging one's impulses, but you have to keep your larger goals in mind. Red has a bad habit of doing something one day that causes problems the next day.

My other ally is Blue. I adore how much Blue thinks everything through. Like me, Blue has a plan. Blue has figured out what it wants and takes careful steps to get it. Unlike Red, Blue never makes a move without calculating the ripples it will create. Blue is often more thorough than me, although that comes at the cost of it being a little slower at advancement than I'm happy with.

Blue also understands the power of knowledge. Part of being victorious is understanding the weaknesses of those in your way. Blue understands that knowledge is power and is great at figuring out how to defeat someone in an unexpected way. Blue is underhanded, sneaky, and manipulative. I say all of this in the most positive way. Blue doesn't fall for White's "morality" scam. Blue does what Blue needs to do.

I also admire Blue's use of other resources. Blue realizes that there are limitations to what it can do, and it has spent a lot of time finding new tools, techniques, and secrets that will allow it to accomplish its goals.

My main criticism of Blue would be that they're a little too caught up in reaching the ideal. There's a gap between what gets the job done and the best possible outcome. I'm all about practicality. If something works, I'm happy. Blue always aims for the optimal outcome, and that slows it down. Also, Blue is not willing to take risks, something that's often necessary. Blue values something being right over it being good enough.

Now that I've talked about the other colors, it's time to talk about my strengths and weaknesses. My greatest strength is my ability to see opportunities. I am incredibly focused and ruthless when it comes to getting what I want. Every other color has rules for why they won't do certain things. I do none of that. I don't create limitations. If something will help me get what I want, I'm willing to use it. I have no taboos. I have no qualms. I have no hesitations. I have no mercy. I simply know what I want and am willing to do what needs to be done.

There are two reasons I can do this. First, I am not attached to anything. To get what you want, you often must give up something else of value. I will do that every time. If giving up something gets me something that I need, I will give up what I must, even if it took a lot of time to acquire. My sacrifices are just stepping stones to something else. Second, I am willing to take risks. To win, you must be willing to lose. My risks are always calculated, but I am willing to embrace the possibility of losing things dear to me in my quest for power.

This, of course, leads me to my biggest weakness. Things won't always work out for me. Some risks won't go my way, and that can lead to some major setbacks. My willingness to mess with forces that no other color will can sometimes backfire. With risk comes reward, but also punishment.

I understand that my ways might sound harsh, but I'm the only color that prioritizes getting you what you need and want. Every other color will try to get you to settle and tell you that it's okay not to have all the things you want. But why? You only get one life, and there's only one you. There's nothing wrong with each person being their own champion. If you don't look out for yourself, who will?

Thanks for listening. I hope what I had to say hits home.

Before I go, Mark wants to hear what you all think about this article. He wanted to remind you that you can email him or contact him through social media (Bluesky, Tumblr, Instagram, TikTok, and Twitter).

I'm supposed to say join Mark next week for another installment of *Making Magic*.

Until then, always remember it's okay to put yourself first.

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